



PURUSHOTTAM DWIVAKAR

THE NEW GRAVES HAVE SPARKED A FURIOUS DEBATE; (FAR LEFT) A SKETCH OF RAZIA'S GRAVE

graves have been laid was the most appropriate way to lay to rest a sultan and her trusted slave," says Shahibzadah Abdul Moid Khan, director of the Maulana Abdul Kalam Azad Arabic-Persian Research Institute, Tonk, and a descendant of the ruling nawabs of Tonk. "Look at the monuments and the scrawl on the graves. These are of the Sultanate period and of royal descendants," he adds. Such twin graves, he says, are rare. "The difference in stature yet proximity has been very clear in these graves," he says. He also believes, however, that the new evi-

dence needs to be researched further. There also are conflicting versions of the date of Razia's death and burial. Historians interpret the dates of her defeat at Kaithal and her death as alternate days while Ali and Khan say this was a wrong interpretation and it is actually a difference of one month.

If true, it means there was enough time for an injured Razia to have reached a place she considered safe. Medieval history does refer to her escaping in a man's disguise, being given shelter but then killed by Hindu farmers. Ali strongly counters this theory,

saying Razia was known for her secular credentials and was the first Muslim ruler to have fought along with Rajputs and other castes. "If the crucial fact of one month between her death and the Kaithal defeat could be ignored for centuries, there can be other facts also that need to be relooked into," says Ali. Rajasthan's minister for tourism and archaeology Bina Kak is doing just that. She says: "We must find the historical facts behind the graves and surroundings before declaring these as Razia and Yaqut's graves. But I must say this is a significant aspect that needs expert attention." Tourism-wise, an authentic new grave of Razia Sultan could be a goldmine for Tonk.

Indeed, historians have never considered Tonk as having any connection to Razia's life or death though they generally agree that her father had attacked Ranthambore Fort, 50 km from Tonk. There is a mosque atop a hill called *Itumish ki Masjid*. Ranbir Singh Dundlod, who is writing a book on the fort, says Razia herself attacked the fort though he disagrees that she was later buried here. Evidence is slowly piling up, however. Near the mosque named after her father is a dome-like structure which is known as *Rasia ki Tekri* with an incomplete fort wall next to it. In an ancient compound nearby, a huge takht made of a single piece of stone is called *Rasia ka Takht*. Is Razia actually Razia? Dundlod says Razia could never annex Ranthambore but another set of historians do refer to her withdrawing her father's forces, thus winning over the Rajputs. "Rajputana was a safe place for her and Yaqut, and Tonk was known to her," Ali says. Yet, sceptics are not convinced. S.M. Azizuddin Husain, professor, department of history and culture, Jamia Millia Islamia, says all available works indicate that she was buried in Delhi. "I do not agree with the speculation about Tonk," he says. Ali is, however, undeterred. The answer lies buried. ■



“ The twin graves in Tonk are that of Razia Sultan and her trusted slave, Yaqut, as made out from the calligraphic Arabic script on the stones. ”

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